

What don't we know about AI and our data yet, and does it matter?

This chapter helps an owner find the gaps in what the firm knows about AI and about its own data, and close the ones that block a good decision.

[Team name] · [Cohort] · v0.3 · SME: persona/archetype — a fictional 40-person Dutch design-engineering firm, not a real firm (replace if your proposal names one) · Sources last appraised: 1 Oct 2026

The question, for this kind of SME

A 40-person family firm designs machine frames in SOLIDWORKS. Its drawings, part data and orders sit in CAD files, a PDM vault, an ERP system and spreadsheets. The owner asks: what don't we know about AI and our data, and which gaps stop us from deciding?

The size of the gap

- **Little experience.** 74.6% of Dutch non-users cite lack of experience (CBS, 2025).
- **Rules unknown.** Half of Dutch entrepreneurs do not know the AI Act (KVK, 2025).
- **Few data skills.** 27.9% of small EU firms analyse data in-house (Eurostat, 2026).

The translation

1. **What AI can do.** In CAD, AI is a set of small helpers, such as automatic 2D drawings (Albright, 2025). **What to know:** ask “which task, which tool, what result?”
2. **Cost and return.** 65% of SMEs using generative AI see better staff performance, but only 26% see more revenue (OECD, 2025b). **What to know:** a small pilot with a pass level shows the real return.
3. **The rules.** Since February 2025, AI users need AI literacy (European Union, 2024); the GDPR covers personal data (European Union, 2016). **What to know:** training meets the first duty.
4. **Where to get help.** Only 23.6% of SMEs using generative AI train their staff in AI (OECD, 2025b). **What to know:** start with the free National AI Course (FME, n.d.).
5. **Our own data.** Many SMEs say their data is “not in order”, and good data is a precondition for AI (Vankan et al., 2025). **What to know:** find where data lives, who owns it, and if it is usable.

Responsible AI & trust

- **Check every output.** An AI-made drawing is a draft until an engineer checks it.
- **Protect data.** Keep customer drawings out of free chatbots (European Union, 2016).

First five steps for an owner

1. Run an anonymous gap scan and list each data source with its owner.
2. Fix the data source your pilot needs: labels, owner, checks (OECD, 2025a).
3. Let AI users take the free National AI Course, and record it (FME, n.d.; European Union, 2024).
4. Ask your CAD reseller which AI features you have; read KVK on the AI Act.
5. Pick one small pilot, such as auto-drawings, and set a pass level first.

Limits of this page

Desk research only. No source covers engineering firms with 20–75 staff, and our interviews have not yet tested these gaps.

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